

ROT AT THE TOP

Despite exemplary punishments being meted out to senior officers of the Indian Army, a series of graft cases shows that the malaise is deep-rooted

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

A series of raids carried out by the CBI last week yielded cash, property and bank balances worth Rs 50 crore. This was not just another bust, but one at the numerous residences of Major General Anand Kumar Kapoor of the Indian Army. It was unprecedented because the CBI has never raided a serving general, since army personnel are governed by the Army Act. The action, conducted after the approval of Defence Minister A.K. Antony, reveals a disturbing but growing trend of corruption amongst the top brass.

In the last six years, 17 officers of the rank of Brigadier and above have been indicted in corruption and misappropriation of funds which includes the sale of military rations like meat, pulses, liquor and fuel in the open market. The army had recently initiated proceedings against Lt. General S.K. Sahni who retired as DG (Supplies and Transport) last year and Brigadiers P.S. Gill and S.K. Handa for diverting pulses meant for troops involved in counter-insurgency operations in J&K. But this is the first time that a three star officer has been indicted by a military tribunal.

Retired officers say they can't remember a time when the army had caught so many of its generals with their hands in the till but are loath to call it an epidemic. "Among politicians and bureaucrats, it is an exception to be honest, in the army it is an exception to be corrupt", says Major General (rtd) Surjit Singh. The army points out that such cases of embezzlement constitute a tiny fraction, considering the Indian Army has 732 brigadiers, 213 Major Generals and 60 Lt. Generals. "Most of these cases have been unearthed by internal investigations and most have been taken to their logical conclusion at the earliest", says Indian Army spokesperson Colonel

ROLL OF DISHONOUR

Major General A.K. Kapoor
Assets disproportionate to known sources of income. CBI has filed FIR. Raids conducted on Kapoor's properties. Chargesheet yet to be registered.

Lt Gen (Retd) S.K. Sahni, Lt Gen B.P.S. Mander
Brig S.K. Handa, Brig P.S. Gill
Irregularities in the purchase of dry rations. Disciplinary action going on.

Maj Gen (Retd) KTG Nambiar
Financial and other irregularities; loss of three years of past service for pension. Severely reprimanded.

Maj Gen Rana Goswami
Financial and other irregularities. Awarded Severe Displeasure.

G.I. Singh Multani (formerly Maj Gen)
Brig D.S. Grewal, Brig G. Illangovan,
Brig Rajiv Divekar, Brig R.S. Rana
Financial and other irregularities. Multani-cashiered and sentenced to one year RI.

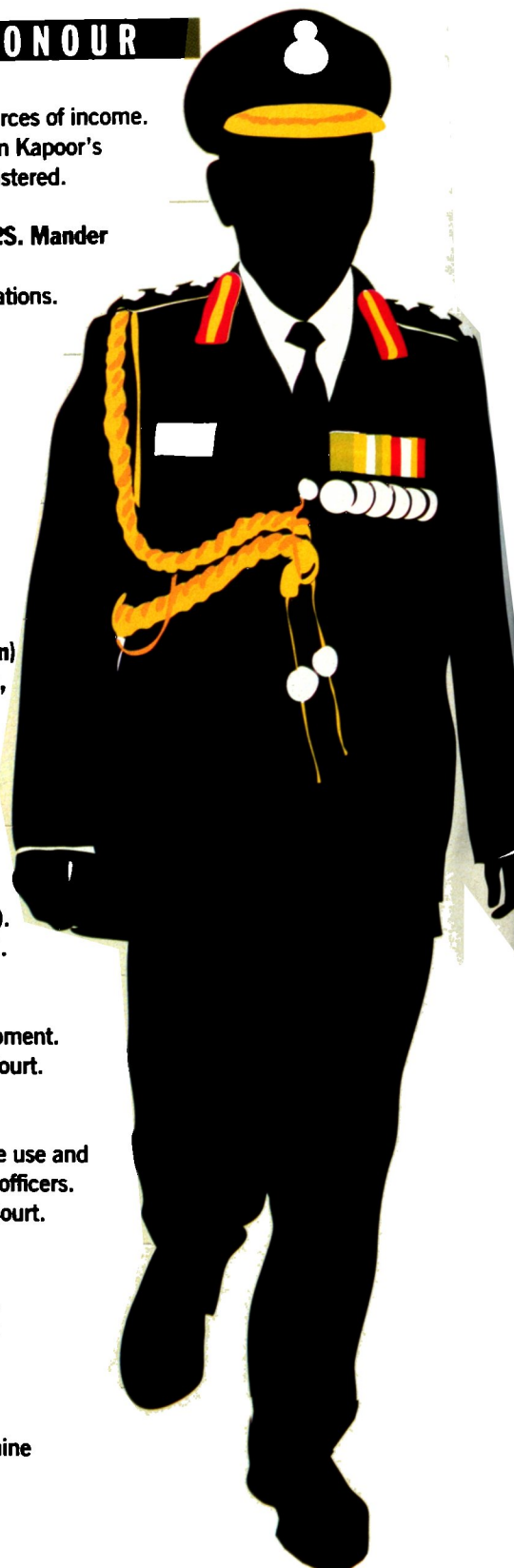
P.S.K Choudhary (formerly Maj Gen), Iqbal Singh (formerly Brig)
Illegal gratification (Tehelka episode). Both officers cashiered. One year RI.

Maj Gen (Retd) L.K. Chopra
Irregularities in purchase of IT equipment. Proceedings stayed by Delhi High Court.

Brig (Retd) V.K. Anand
Misuse of army personnel for private use and obtaining favours from subordinate officers. Proceedings stayed by Delhi High Court.

Lt Gen S.K. Dahiya
Irregularity in frozen meat contract. Recordable censure from GOC-in-C Northern Command.

R.P. Singh (formerly Brig)
Illegal sale of liquor. Sentenced to nine months' RI and cashiered.



SAURABH SINGH